

don't give, God will wipe out their business or their family. That's nonsense. You were saved by grace, and you remain in God's grace by grace. You don't earn that. Tithing is not a way you bribe God into giving you good things or bribe God into keeping bad things from happening. Tithing is an external expression of an internal spiritual commitment. The lack of tithing indicates a couple who no longer truly has God first. " 'Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, so that there may be food in My house, and test Me now in this,' says the Lord of hosts, 'if I will not open for you the windows of heaven, and pour out for you a blessing until it overflows' " (Malachi 3:10).

DANGER SIGN: INCOME = OUTGO

Another danger sign that you must watch for is when your income barely matches your outgo with no savings. You can't remain there. Remember what we talked about in the budgeting section? Five percent of your net spendable income should be put aside for non-allocated savings—not for specific needs, but for expenses you can't anticipate. If your budget is just breaking even and you can't put anything aside, in reality you're not breaking even. You're going under and you just don't know it yet.

The only solution is to cut some of the outgo. Take a look at your budget realistically and say, "Where can we start trimming?" Perhaps a little from entertainment and recreation, a little from miscellaneous and a little from clothing. In other words, wherever possible. As Proverbs 21:20 says, "There is precious treasure and oil in the dwelling of the wise, but a foolish man swallows it up."

So these are some of the danger signs, and you must always *be alert in your marriage to watch for them*. There are many other danger signs, some of which are unrelated to finances. But the nice thing about money is that it is so visible and so measurable.

Just as there is a need to budget, there is a need to do some long-range planning. What are your goals as a couple? Where do you want to be financially 10 or 20 years from now? Few